# There was / there were

Nombre: _____ Fecha: _____

## Qué vas a aprender

- Describe places in the past with there was and there were
- Choose was (singular) or were (plural)
- Make negatives and questions: there wasn't, Was there...?
- Compare a place in the past and now

## Para pensar

**En español decimos «había un castillo» y «había muchos caballos», siempre con «había». En inglés, ¿se dice igual para uno que para muchos?**

## Explicación

### From there is to there was

You already know **there is** and **there are** (hay): «There **is** a park near my house», «There **are** two cinemas in my town». To talk about the **past** we use there was and there were (había, hubo).

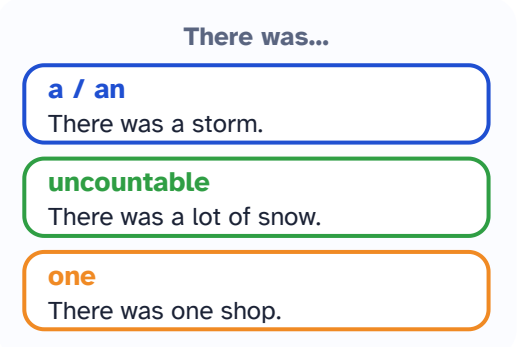
**En castellano:** «hay» pasa a ser «había». En inglés, el singular pasa a *was* y el plural a *were*, igual que el verbo *to be*: is → was, are → were.

| Present | Past |
|---|---|
| **There is a park.** | There was a park. |
| **There are trees.** | There were trees. |

### There was: singular

Use there was with **one** thing (a / an / one) and with **uncountable** nouns (nombres incontables: water, food, snow, money): «There **was a** big storm last night», «There **was an** old tree in the square», «There **was** a lot of snow in the mountains».

The short form **there's** is only for the present. In the past we always write **there was** in full. **En castellano:** «había una tormenta», «había mucha nieve».




### There were: plural

Use there were with **two or more** things: «There **were** twenty children in the classroom», «There **were some** beautiful shells on the beach», «There **were lots of** people at the concert».

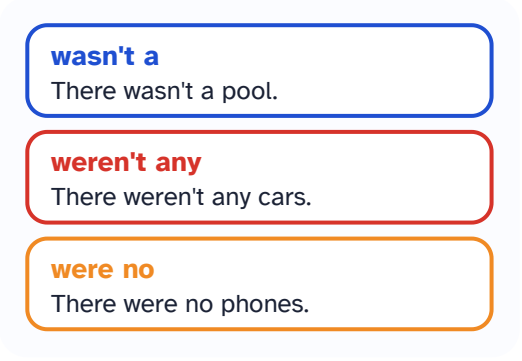
**Careful** with the first noun in a list: «There **was** a table and two chairs» (the first noun is singular) but «There **were** two chairs and a table». **En castellano:** mira la palabra que va justo detrás para elegir *was* o *were*.




## Negatives: there wasn't, there weren't

Negative: there wasn't (was not) and there weren't (were not). With plural and uncountable nouns we usually add **any**: «There **wasn't a** swimming pool», «There **weren't any** cars in 1800», «There **wasn't any** milk in the fridge».

We can also say **there was no** / **there were no**: «There **were no** mobile phones when my grandma was a child». **En castellano:** «no había móviles». Ojo: nunca uses dos negaciones juntas («weren't no»).

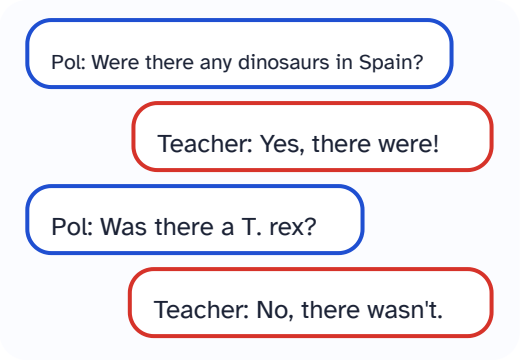



## Questions and short answers

For questions we change the order: Was there...? and Were there...? «**Was there** a library in your school?» – «Yes, there was. / No, there wasn't». «**Were there any**

dinosaurs in Spain?» – «Yes, there were!».

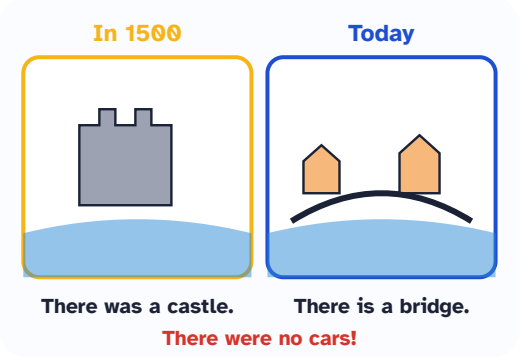
To ask about quantity: «**How many** people **were there**?» (countable) and «**How much** food **was there**?» (uncountable). **En castellano:** «¿Cuántas personas había?», «¿Cuánta comida había?».




## My town in the past

We use there was / there were to **describe places** long ago: «A hundred years ago there **weren't** any supermarkets in my town. There **was** a small market in the square. There **were** lots of farms and there **was** a railway station. There **wasn't** any electricity in some houses».

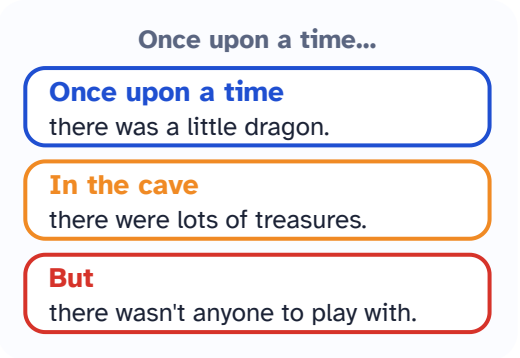
Compare with today using there is / there are: «Now there **is** a big supermarket and there **are** two schools». **Consejo:** pregunta a tus abuelos cómo era su pueblo y escríbelo en inglés.




## Telling a story

Stories often start with there was or there were to present the place and the characters: «Once upon a time **there was** a little dragon who lived in a cave. **There were** lots of treasures in the cave, but **there wasn't** anyone to play with».

We use it to describe a scene: «When we arrived at the party, **there was** music and **there were** balloons everywhere». **En castellano:** «Érase una vez un dragón...» se dice en inglés «Once upon a time there was a dragon...».




## Reading: a school trip to a castle

Read Nerea's text: «Last Friday we visited a castle. It was very old. Many years ago, **there were** soldiers and horses there. **There was** a big kitchen with a huge fireplace, but **there wasn't** a bathroom! **There were** some secret tunnels under the castle. «**Were there** any ghosts?» asked Mario. «No, **there weren't**», said the guide. «But **there was** a very old cat!». We all laughed.»

How many times do you see *there was*? And *there were*?




## Let's practise: memory game

Look at a picture of a room for one minute. Then close your eyes. Your partner asks: «**Was there** a lamp?», «**How many** books **were there**?». Answer: «Yes, there was», «There were three books». Who remembers more?

Then describe a place you visited: «In the zoo **there were** lions and **there was** a big aquarium». **Consejo:** antes de escribir *was* o *were*, mira si lo que viene detrás

es uno, varios o incontable.

| Question | Answer |
| --- | --- |
| **Was there a lamp?** | Yes, there was. |
| **Were there any cats?** | No, there weren't. |
| **How many books?** | There were three. |

## There was / there were

singular

**THERE WAS**

a castle
some snow

plural

**THERE WERE**

two towers
lots of people

negative

**WASN'T / WEREN'T**

any cars
a bathroom

question

**WAS THERE...?**

Yes, there was.
No, there weren't.

## Ejercicios

1. **Complete: «There ___ a big storm yesterday.»**

2. **Complete: «There ___ ten pencils in my bag.»**

3. **Complete: «There ___ much water in the river.» (negative)**

4. **Make it negative: «There were some biscuits.»**

5. **Make a question: «There was a museum in your town.»**

6. **Short answer: «Were there any people?» (no)**

7. **Ask with How many: «There were five boats.»**

8. **Correct: «In 1900 it had no computers.»**

9. **Translate: «Había un perro y dos gatos.»**

10. **Write three sentences about your classroom in 1° of Primary.**

## Practica

1. **«There ___ a cat on the roof.»**
   - **A)** were
   - **B)** was
   - **C)** had
2. **«There ___ two cats on the roof.»**
   - **A)** was
   - **B)** is
   - **C)** were
3. **«There ___ any milk.»**
   - **A)** wasn't
   - **B)** weren't
   - **C)** isn't no
4. **«___ there a park in your town?»**
   - **A)** Were
   - **B)** Did
   - **C)** Was
5. **«Were there any shops?» – «No, ___.»**
   - **A)** there wasn't
   - **B)** there weren't
   - **C)** they weren't
6. **«How many children ___?»**
   - **A)** were there
   - **B)** there were
   - **C)** was there
7. **«Había» in English is...**
   - **A)** it had
   - **B)** there was / there were
   - **C)** there has
8. **«There ___ a lot of snow last winter.»**
   - **A)** were

**B)** are

**C)** was

9. **«There were ___ phones in 1850.»**

**A)** no

**B)** not

**C)** any no

10. **Present of «there were» is...**

**A)** there is

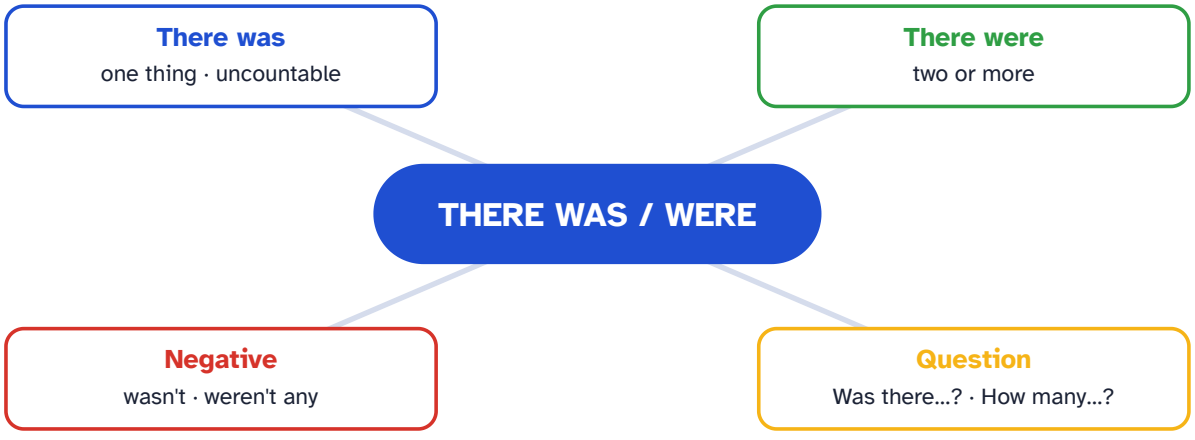
**B)** there are

**C)** there have

## Explícalo con tus palabras

Incluye: Qué significan there was y there were; Cuándo se usa was y cuándo were; Cómo se hacen las negativas con any y no; Cómo se pregunta y se contesta con respuestas cortas.

## Resumen



## Tarjetas de repaso

Recórtalas: pregunta delante, respuesta detrás.

**there was**

Había (una cosa o incontable).

**there were**

Había (varias cosas).

**there wasn't**

No había (singular).

**there weren't any**

No había ningunos.

**Was there...?**

¿Había...? (singular).

**Were there...?**

¿Había...? (plural).

**How many ... were there?**

¿Cuántos ... había?

**Once upon a time there was...**

Érase una vez...

## Soluciones

1. **B)** Una cosa: was.
2. **C)** Plural: were.
3. **A)** Incontable, negativa.
4. **C)** Singular: Was there...?
5. **B)** Respuesta corta.
6. **A)** Orden de pregunta, plural.
7. **B)** No se usa had.
8. **C)** Snow es incontable.
9. **A)** were no = no había.
10. **B)** were → are.

## Soluciones de los ejercicios

1. was.
2. were.
3. wasn't.
4. There weren't any biscuits.
5. Was there a museum in your town?
6. No, there weren't.
7. How many boats were there?
8. In 1900 there were no computers.
9. There was a dog and two cats.
10. Model answer: There were lots of toys. There was a big carpet. There weren't any computers.